

Tidal pools in a wave-cut platform form a metacommunity on Eysturoy in the Faroe Islands. The tidal pools are separate between tides, but become joined as one when the tide comes in.

Blurred communities

Leibold’s 2004 paper acknowledged that the metacommunities with blurred boundaries are perhaps the hardest to define. Coral reefs, for example, may look neatly separate, but many of the species that live among them swim freely and respond to a host of changing outside influences, such as shifts in ocean currents.